


‘Irfan: Lectures on Islamic Mysticism

The Lecture Series



Book One · Faithful edition

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Seeking, not powers: what ‘Irfan is

A mysterious subject

Mysticism is mysterious. No one quite knows what it is. Even mystics are unsure what mysticism really is, except for the real mystics. Nor is mysticism limited to Islam: some people with no religion at all feel drawn to it. This makes it harder to tell Islamic mysticism, *‘Irfan*, apart from other kinds of mysticism, and it is very important to do so.

People come to mysticism for many reasons. Some want an extraordinary power, such as being in two places at the same time. They set out to explore the mysteries of the unknown world of the human soul so that they may gain some power. That is one kind of mysticism, found in other religions, and the real mystic has to be distinguished from it. So the first questions are what is being discussed, who the mystics are, and what they want. They take on a journey that is “exhausting, time consuming, life consuming”. The sayings of the Imams (‘a), their supplications and some verses of the Quran show a kind of mysticism very different from the mysticism found in other religions. The first task, then, is to find out what is being sought.

Why go beyond the obligatory?

Before asking what the mystics seek, one has to ask why anyone should seek it at all. A man once went to the Prophet ﷺ and admitted that he had no



eagerness for *salat al-layl*, the night prayer, or for recommended (*mustahabb*) fasting and the like. If he prayed his five daily prayers, fasted in Ramadan, paid his zakat and went to hajj once, would he go to *janna*? The Prophet said yes: if he did these things, he would go to paradise. [VERIFY: source of this hadith] If paradise is so easily reached by performing the obligatory (*wajib*) duties, why work so hard? Why take on the hard endeavour that is mysticism?

The question is all the sharper because some Muslim jurists and activists are completely against mysticism. In their view you follow whatever the *shari'a* has told you and you go to paradise; there is no other way. Mysticism, they say, is silly, something made up by certain mystics according to their own feelings and wishes. Is that true? Are Muslims encouraged to take this path or not? The way to find out is to see what the Quran says.

The signs in Surah Rum

The lecture takes a few verses from Surah Rum. There are many more there and elsewhere in the same vein. Each verse names a sign of God and then says for whom the sign is meant.

The first reads:

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ أَنْ خَلَقَ لَكُمْ مِنْ أَنْفُسِكُمْ أَزْوَاجًا لِتَسْكُنُوا إِلَيْهَا وَجَعَلَ بَيْنَكُمْ
مَوَدَّةً وَرَحْمَةً إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ ﴿٢١﴾

*And one of the signs is that He created mates for you from yourself,
that you may dwell in tranquillity with them, and He has put love
and mercy between your hearts: verily in that are signs for those who
reflect.*

Quran 30:21

What signs? Does everyone see a sign of God in the relationship between a man and a woman? Usually, the lecture observes, what people see in it is the sign of Shaytan. The signs are there, but they are not for everyone. They are for people who reflect.

The next verse reads:



وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ خَلْقُ السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ وَاخْتِلَافُ أَلْسِنَتِكُمْ وَالْوَلَوِكُمْ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّلْعَالِمِينَ ﴿٢٢﴾

And from the signs is the creation of the heavens and the earth and the diversity of your tongues and colours: verily in that are signs for those who know.

Quran 30:22

What people usually see in the diversity of peoples is ethnic difference, and with it racism. What sign of God do they see there? There are signs in it for the knowledgeable and for the learned, but not for everyone. Whoever sees the signs in it is learned. Most people do not. Not even most pious people see them, and not even most of those who are very strict about the shari‘a.

Then:

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ مَنَامُكُمْ بِاللَّيْلِ وَالنَّهَارِ وَابْتِغَاؤُكُمْ مِّنْ فَضْلِهِ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٢٣﴾

And among His signs is the sleep that you take by night and by day, and the quest that you make for livelihood out of His bounty: verily in that are signs for those who hear.

Quran 30:23

Do we not hear? If we hear, why do we not break down when we see these signs, as the prophets and the friends of God, the *awliya*’ Allah, break down when they see the signs of Allah?

And the last of the verses chosen:

وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ يُرِيكُمُ الْبَرْقَ خَوْفًا وَطَمَعًا وَيُنْزِلُ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَيُحْيِي بِهِ الْأَرْضَ بَعْدَ مَوْتِهَا إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَعْقِلُونَ ﴿٢٤﴾

And among His signs, He shows you the lightning, by way both of fear and of hope, and He sends down rain from the sky and with it gives life to the earth after it is dead: verily in that are signs for those who are wise.

Quran 30:24



Read in this way, the verses are uncomfortable. “Actually,” the lecturer says, “the Quran is insulting us.” It tells us that we do not understand, do not hear, do not reflect and are not learned. “I don’t know about you. I feel that the Quran is insulting.” The Quran says much the same elsewhere, when it speaks of people who have ears and eyes by which they do not hear and see.

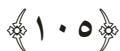
The inner machine

So what is wrong? The organ of hearing does its job: it catches the sound. But there is something inside that does not catch it. In the lecture’s image, “there is a machine inside which is rust[ed] and doesn’t see these signs.” Many people have heard these verses over and over, and some have felt that there are signs in them which they cannot see. Out of obedience one can say: the Quran says there are signs, so there are signs. That is fine as far as it goes. But what must one do to catch the sign, to hear it and reflect on it?

Here the lecture sums up the whole subject: “Mysticism is all about making one’s soul to hear, to see and to reflect.” This is the summary of Islamic mysticism. The rest of the course is meant to show how it can be done, because it is very difficult.

How can a person prepare himself to hear? There are many signs that go unseen:

وَكَايْنِ مِّنْ ءَايَةٍ فِي السَّمٰوٰتِ وَٱلْاَرْضِ يَمُرُّنَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ



And how many signs in the heavens and the earth do they pass by? Yet they turn their faces away from them.

Quran 12:105

We do not see. Something is wrong. Put in a single expression, the task is to fix the inner machine, which is the soul. It is broken and does not work. It has to be repaired so that it can catch the signals of God. “And this is not of course a joke and not an easy path. It needs lots of training.”

The image comes back with a verse that, as the lectures note, comes up in different phases of the Quran:



وَلَقَدْ ذَرَأْنَا لِجَهَنَّمَ كَثِيرًا مِّنَ الْجِنِّ وَالْإِنسِ لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا
وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أُذَانٌ لَا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَا أُولَٰئِكَ
كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْغَافِلُونَ ﴿١٧٩﴾

They have hearts by which they do not understand, they have eyes by which they do not see, and they have ears by which they do not hear.

They are like animals, and even worse.

Quran 7:179

Animals have eyes and ears. Do they not see and hear? They certainly do. They see where they walk, and when they hear a sound they run away. So what is the comparison with animals about?

The answer is the inner machine. Something inside the human being has to translate what is seen and heard so that it reaches the reality. What we see and hear is only on the surface; it is superficial. Only some people understand the reality of those things. Animals see and hear, but they do not have the machine to translate it. Unbelievers (*kuffar*) see and hear too. Tell them they have eyes with which they do not see, and they will laugh and say they see better, in more detail and more artistically. The Quran grants that they see, but it says they do not understand. The lecture promises that this enigma will come back again and again in the course: having and not having, listening and not listening, being and not being.

We see and hear with the mind and the eyes, which give only a sight of the thing. We have the machine, the soul, but it is not working. It is dead and blind. Mysticism teaches how to ignite this machine inside us. Once it starts working, the real work of the mystic begins: it is the beginning of the move. Everyone says that mysticism has an end. It has no end, but it does have a beginning. The beginning is the moment the machine starts to work, and from then on one sees the wonders of this world.

Not a search for powers

Self-training is done for many purposes. Many mystics train themselves to gain powers, for example, or to see the future or the past. Islamic mysticism is not about this. It is about catching the signs of Allah, becoming sensitive to them,



and hearing and seeing them. Among the verses the lecture calls “very moving” is this one:

قُلْ أَرَأَيْتُمْ إِنْ جَعَلَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْكُمُ اللَّيْلَ سَرْمَدًا إِلَى يَوْمِ الْقِيَمَةِ مِنْ إِلَهٍ غَيْرِ
اللَّهِ يَأْتِيكُمْ بَضِيَاءٌ أَفَلَا تَسْمَعُونَ ﴿٧١﴾

Say: See you? If Allah were to make the night perpetual over you to the Day of Judgement, what god is there other than Allah who can give you enlightenment? Are you not hearing?

Quran 28:71

This is what catches the signals that God sends, and what lies beyond them. When a person becomes ready to receive those signals, he has only just started his machine, but now it can work. Once it works, God knows what kinds of signals he may see and hear. No one can reckon what mystics see and hear. Once the machine is fixed and the soul uplifted, only God really knows what they see. The transcript then appears to say that the Imams are at the very peak of such people. [QUERY: L01 ¶14 is transcribed as "the things that the kaafir see and the imam sees of course they are the peak". "Kaafir" looks like a mishearing, perhaps of "kamil" or "awliya". What did the lecturer say here?]

Those brought near

Who, then, are the mystics? There are two groups of people: those whose soul works and those whose soul does not work at all. The first are called ‘*urafa*’, the plural of ‘*arif*’, which means “someone who knows”. The others are *jahala*, those who do not know and do not have the capability to know and understand.

The prophets and the Imams are very special ‘*urafa*’, but they are not the subject here. Neither are the unbelievers. The question concerns ordinary people. Ordinary believers (*mu’minun*) do have an understanding, but the Quran also mentions a special group of people with a special understanding, different from the ordinary believers. One name it gives them is *muqarrabun*, “those who are brought near”. Yet Allah is not far away; He is very near. In what sense, then, are they brought near? In the sense, it seems, that some veil that stood between ordinary people and Allah has been taken away. They understand far better. That is what it means to be *muqarrab*.



The muqarrabun fall into four categories, which are named in Surah Nisa’:

وَمَنْ يُطِيعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ
وَالصَّادِقِينَ وَالشُّهَدَاءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُولَٰئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Anyone who obeys Allah’s prophet, they will be of those on whom Allah has bestowed favour.

Quran 4:69

Some people have the favour of Allah. What is this favour? It is certainly not wealth or a strong body. It is something else. Those favoured are the prophets (*nabiyyin*), the truthful (*siddiqin*), the witnesses (*shuhada’*) and, at the end, the righteous (*salihin*). The lecturer is “sure” of having talked about the first three groups on an earlier occasion, but says the salihin were never explained, “because it was not possible”. [QUERY: L01 ¶15 refers back to an earlier talk on the four categories of muqarrabun. Is it part of this series?]

The first three groups are very special, and ordinary people cannot reach their level. The salihin are “very good”, and they stand at the bottom of the muqarrabun. They are the ones who deserve this favour, or who have the capacity to be given it. It is only from among the salihin that Allah chooses the other categories: from them He chooses the siddiqin, and from them the prophets. Of some prophets Allah says that He made them prophets because they were of the salihin. Of *Lut* He says:

وَأَدْخَلْنَاهُ فِي رَحْمَتِنَا إِنَّهُ مِنَ الصَّالِحِينَ ﴿٧٥﴾

We made him enter into Our mercy. He was from the salihin.

Quran 21:75

This is a special mercy, and Lut deserved it because he belonged to this category. The salihin are people who understand better than we do, and who see and hear better than we do.

The prophets, the Imams and the siddiqin are all among the muqarrabun. But ordinary people can also enter the realm of the muqarrabun, and that realm makes them completely different from other people. The Quran distinguishes them from the other believers: in Surah Waq’ah it separates the mu’minun from the muqarrabun, and the muqarrabun are a group from among the awliya’ Allah. Entering even the last category of the muqarrabun



is very difficult. “And that,” the lecture says, “is what Islamic mysticism is about.”

The usual understanding is that religion is only the shari‘a: follow it, succeed and go to paradise. That is fair enough, and it holds for ordinary believers. For the muqarrabun, “the whole terms and conditions are different.” They are after something else and are completely different. They are given paradise in this world itself; in the next world they seek something else. They become members of the awliya’ Allah and the proof of Allah. They are the true ‘urafa’, or mystics. “Mystic” is a very general term, used for Christian, Hindu and Buddhist mystics. ‘Arif, as the lecture puts it, is “a very nice term” that is used in Islam when someone becomes a true knower.

What the mystics ask for

The clearest evidence of what the ‘urafa’ want comes from the supplications. Many people have recited the *Munajat Sha‘baniyyah*. It is reported from Imam ‘Ali (‘a) and Imam Zayn al-‘Abidin (‘a), and all the Imams used to recite it and supplicate with it. It shows what is being asked of God, and believers are told to ask for the same. The lecturer admits to sometimes wondering why we are told to recite such words. It is like telling a primary school boy to read university books. The words are very hard. They come from the peak of the understanding and eagerness of the muqarrabun.

The passage opens: “My Lord, grant me complete severance of my relation with everything else” [VERIFY: *Munajat Sha‘baniyyah* wording]. Is it good to cut oneself off completely from everything else? In the heart, yes. The Quran says the same:

وَاذْكُرْ اسْمَ رَبِّكَ وَتَبَتَّلْ إِلَيْهِ تَبْتِيلًا ﴿٨﴾

Cut off from everything and devote yourself to Him wholeheartedly.

Quran 73:8

This goes beyond the sensitivity to signs described in the verses of Surah Rum.

The supplication continues: “Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at You” [VERIFY: *Munajat Sha‘baniyyah* wording]. If our eyes work, why do we not see the signs? Because there is another mechanism that has to respond to what it receives. It does not respond, because it is blind. And what do the mystics mean by looking at God? Is it possible at all? The Quran says



that God can never be seen [VERIFY: the lecture gives no Quranic reference here], yet here the du’a speaks of the light of looking at Him. It goes further still: “until the eyes of our hearts penetrate the veils of light” [VERIFY: Munajat Sha‘baniyyah wording]. The mystics talk about such things, and people unfamiliar with their language sometimes say that these words are mistakes.

The mystics say there are veils of light and darkness. A person has to pierce them until he reaches the very origin of Allah’s grandeur (*‘azama*) and majesty (*kibriya*). And the same thing is here in the du’a: the eyes of the heart pierce the veils of light “and reach the source of grandeur” [VERIFY: Munajat Sha‘baniyyah wording]. The source of Allah’s grandeur is something we cannot understand, because we cannot know it or think about it. Yet the mystics want to know Him and to look at Him; they want to be drawn towards Him. First, of course, they have to cut themselves off from everything. The lecture paraphrases the whole passage in this way: teach me that severance from everything else, until the eyes of my heart are enlightened; then I can look, pierce the veils of light, look into the source of grandeur, and “let our souls be suspended by the glory of Your sanctity” [VERIFY: Munajat Sha‘baniyyah wording]. If we do not know what they are talking about, that does not make it senseless or meaningless. [QUERY: L01 ¶21 first reads "Certainly we know what they are talking about", then "if we don't know what they are talking about it doesn't mean that it is senseless". Is the first sentence a transcription slip for "we don't know"?]

The munajat goes on: “My Lord, make me one of those whom You call and they respond, and when You look at them they are struck by Your majesty” [VERIFY: Munajat Sha‘baniyyah wording]. This is something like what prophets do: God calls and they respond. When He looks into their souls, they are thunderstruck by the majesty they see. “This is the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah. We cannot say that this is not good.”

All the Imams recited this munajat, and believers are told to recite it in the month of Sha‘ban. The lecturer recommends reciting it in Sha‘ban as much as possible. Much of its meaning is beyond us, but we have been honoured by being allowed to recite it, for it is not within our capacity or at our level. It is as though Allah says: come and recite this, and if you are sincere, perhaps I will grant it to you. What the Imams wanted, Allah granted them. Most of the munajat’s other sentences are like these.

Another line runs: “My Lord, place me among Your friends, in the position of one who hopes for an increase in Your love” [VERIFY: Munajat Sha‘baniyyah



wording]. The word for friendship here, *wilaya*, carries two meanings. The first is *ma'rifah*: understanding God, looking at Him, knowing Him. The second is love for Him. Ma'rifah and love are the true meaning of wilaya, and they are what the mystics "can fly" by. These are exactly what the mystics ask for: incessant love for Allah and ever-increasing ma'rifah. This happens only after the machine is fixed, starts to work and shows the signals of Allah. The one who asks this has found a passionate love of remembering God, so that he remembers only Him. The lecture then quotes a further line of the munajat, saying that this is the line taken to explain the position of the muqarrabun.

[GAP: L01 ¶24 quotes a further line of the munajat in transliteration, with no translation or explanation.]

Animals with the capacity to become human

Can a human being reach such knowledge and such love of Allah? The lecture's answer starts from what human beings are. We are wrong to call ourselves human beings. We are not yet human beings. We are animals with the potential to become human. We were created as animals, but we have the capacity to become human beings like the prophets, who are real human beings.

A human being has the capacity to become a friend of God. Allah created us with this capacity and wants us to reach it. Instead, in the transcript's words, "we have become his enemy than becoming his strength". [QUERY: L01 ¶25 has "strength". Did the lecturer say "strength" or "friend"?] So what makes these people different from others? How, in their ordinary lives, are they able to fix the machine?

The friends of God

The answer is found in the description of the awliya' Allah in the *Nahj al-Balagha*. The lecture uses awliya' Allah as a synonym for the 'urafa', the mystics. Imam 'Ali ('a) says that the friends of Allah are those who look at the inward side of the world, while other people look at its outward side, at what is on the surface. The awliya' look deeper, and that is why they please Allah.

How are they able to do this, and why are we not? The transcript's answer is only partly legible: they busy themselves with one thing, while other people busy themselves with another. [GAP: L01 ¶26 reads "they busy themselves with



29:49 while the other people busy themselves in the imaging". The verse reference stands in for a quotation, and "imaging" may be a mishearing.] An example follows. There is nothing wrong with being rich. [QUERY: L01 ¶26 first says "it is wrong according to shariah to become rich", then "It is nothing wrong if you are rich". Probably a transcription slip for "not wrong". Please confirm.] The trouble comes when a person gets busy with these things. Then he can never reach the station of the awliya' Allah.

The awliya' never think about themselves; they always think about God. They are completely cut off from other things. Ordinary people have families, friends and a social position. The awliya' may have these too, but in the heart they are completely cut off from them. They stay far away and aloof from what goes on with other people. [QUERY: L01 ¶26 reads "we have family, we have friends, we have social position, we don't think but in the heart we are completely cut off from him." The pronouns are unclear. Is the point that the awliya' are cut off in the heart from worldly ties, or that ordinary people are cut off in the heart from God?] This is only a short statement of the passage. The lecturer calls it "a very nice prescription" of the awliya' Allah and advises students to read the rest for themselves. [VERIFY: the lecture cites this as "sermon 432" of the Nahj al-Balagha; the number may refer to a saying rather than a sermon.]

A second supplication

A second supplication shows the same longing. It comes from the Fifteen Whispered Prayers (*Munajat al-Khamsa 'Ashar*) in the *Sahifa Sajjadiyya*, from Imam Zayn al-'Abidin ('a). Reading it, one might think its author had left society and spent his whole life in a cave, devoted completely to Allah. Look at what he says.

"My God, who can have tasted the sweetness of Your love and then be after anything else?" [VERIFY: *Sahifa Sajjadiyya*, *Munajat al-Khamsa 'Ashar*, wording] If you are after other things, you have not tasted the sweetness of His love. "And who is the one who has been near You and then wants to go somewhere else?" [VERIFY: *Sahifa Sajjadiyya* wording] Whoever has become familiar with the nearness of Allah has no wish to go anywhere else.

The prayer goes on to ask: "Place us among those whom You have chosen for Your nearness, love and friendship, whom You have purified completely for Your love and affection, whom You have made eager to meet You, and to whom You have given the gift of looking at Your face" [VERIFY: *Sahifa Sajjadiyya*



wording]. Such people are able to look at His face. For now this seems meaningless. As the course goes on, the lecture promises, it will become clear what looking at the face of Allah means.

The prayer speaks of those to whom God has given “refuge from the pain of separation from You” **[VERIFY: Sahifa Sajjadiyya wording]**. For some people, separation is painful. When they call on Allah, He seems completely absent. They call Him and want to cry out to the sky, because they are so far away from Him. Other people feel His presence when they call Him. They respond in a way that makes them break down and faint, as the Imams did. Sometimes, when the Imams called on Allah, they fainted, because they sensed His nearness and His response so heavily.

The prayer continues: “You have chosen them for Your true knowledge, made them worthy of Your worship, and captivated their hearts for Your will” **[VERIFY: Sahifa Sajjadiyya wording]**. The word behind this, *hayam*, means more than “captivated”. It is a love that is never quenched. The same idea is found in what is said about certain angels, the *muhayyamin*, who are burnt in the love of Allah **[VERIFY: source of the reference to the muhayyamin angels]**. They look at Him in such a way that they cannot turn their faces away. Elsewhere there are angels standing in rows, watching God, so absorbed that they seem dumb. When other angels ask them anything, they cannot hear and they cannot see. They are completely absorbed in Him. The one who prays asks to be given this hayam.

Some mystics have felt this kind of love of Allah. Some, after finding hayam, could not speak for the rest of their lives. “I don’t say it is good,” the lecturer remarks. Someone with enough capacity can come back, as the Prophet ﷺ went on the *mi’raj* and came back. That needs great capacity, of course, on the Prophet’s part. The prayer also speaks of one whose heart God “has made burn with the love of seeking You” **[VERIFY: Sahifa Sajjadiyya wording]**.

A special class of believers in the Quran

The supplications show what the mystics ask for. The Quran shows that such people exist. It speaks of a group of believers, not prophets or Imams, whose understanding is different from that of ordinary believers. Several verses describe them.

In Surah Anfal:



إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِذَا تُلِيَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتُهُ
زَادَتْهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَعَلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ يَتَوَكَّلُونَ ﴿٢﴾

Mu'minun are those who, when the name of Allah is mentioned, their heart trembles.

Quran 8:2

Is there anyone whose heart trembles on hearing the name of Allah? “Even if we have,” the lecturer jokes, “we are not going to reveal this secret.” In any case, these are not ordinary believers. What quality must a person have for his heart to tremble when Allah’s name is mentioned? To be frightened, numbed or shaken by something, a person must already have some idea or experience of it. So there are believers who know Allah, and that is why their hearts tremble at His name. They are not ordinary believers.

Then:

قَدْ أَفْلَحَ الْمُؤْمِنُونَ ﴿١﴾ الَّذِينَ هُمْ فِي صَلَاتِهِمْ خَاشِعُونَ ﴿٢﴾

These are the mu'minun who are humble in their prayers.

Quran 23:1-2

“It is not me certainly,” the lecturer says, “and many of you might not be like this.” These are the people who feel humility in their hearts when they stand before Allah. The *khashi* is someone who is broken. This is more than humility. It is an experience that brings a person down inside himself. Such a believer is different from ordinary believers. When these people stand before Allah in salah they break down, because of the experience they have of Allah. Can Allah be experienced at all? “This is what mysticism is all about.” Is there a way, a channel, a path to Allah?

Higher still is a verse from Surah Al ‘Imran, one of the great verses of the Quran, which only people of high knowledge can understand:

شَهِدَ اللَّهُ أَنَّهُ لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ وَالْمَلَائِكَةُ وَأُولُوا الْعِلْمِ قَائِمًا بِالْقِسْطِ لَا إِلَهَ
إِلَّا هُوَ الْعَزِيزُ الْحَكِيمُ ﴿١٨﴾

There is no god but He: that is the witness of Allah, His angels, and those endued with knowledge.

Quran 3:18



Allah has knowledge of His own oneness (*tawhid*). We also have knowledge of tawhid, but it cannot be compared with Allah's knowledge of His own tawhid. He witnesses that there is no god and no being beside Him. The angels witness it too, and so do certain human beings: *ulu al-'ilm*, those endowed with knowledge. This is another expression for the 'arif. The 'urafa', those who have ma'rifah, witness the tawhid of Allah.

Tawhid is a very difficult concept once one starts to think about it. It is not as simple as just saying that there is no god but Allah. That is its simplest meaning. To understand it more deeply, one cannot rely on the intellect alone. One has to start up and ignite the machine inside, the soul. Only that part of a person can grasp tawhid and the meaning of this verse. It is said that the verses of the Quran have layers of depth: seven layers to each verse, seventy beneath each of those, and seven hundred beneath each of the seventy [VERIFY: source of the tradition on the layers of the Quran]. One person understands something from a verse, and someone else understands it much more deeply. The meaning and concept are the same, but they are understood at different levels.

Another verse reads:

وَمِنَ النَّاسِ وَالْدَّوَابِّ وَالْأَنْعَامِ مُخْتَلِفٌ أَلْوَنُهُ كَذَلِكَ إِنَّمَا يَخْشَى اللَّهَ مِنْ عِبَادِهِ الْعُلَمَاءُ إِنَّ اللَّهَ عَزِيزٌ غَفُورٌ ﴿٢٨﴾

Only those who are possessed of knowledge have fear of Allah.

Quran 35:28

This is a short translation of only the part of the verse under discussion. In a way, everyone fears Allah, but most people fear His punishment more than they fear Him. Some people fear Him and not His punishment. Their hearts are filled with a fear that cannot be explained. It is not fear of punishment; it is something else.

These are only a few examples. The Quran mentions people who are different, and this cannot be denied. There are other expressions too. The *ulu al-albab* are those who have inner intellect. And there are the friends of God:

أَلَا إِنَّ أَوْلِيَاءَ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Verily on the friends of Allah there is no fear, nor shall they grieve.

Quran 10:62



Again, this is a group of people who are different from us. How does someone become a friend of Allah and connect very closely with Him? The answer depends on how the term *wali* is translated.

Finally, a verse in Surah Nahl:

مَنْ عَمِلَ صَالِحًا مِّنْ ذَكَرٍ أَوْ أُنْثَىٰ وَهُوَ مُؤْمِنٌ فَلَنُحْيِيَنَّهٗ حَيٰوةً طَيِّبَةً
وَلَنَجْزِيَنَّهُمْ أَجْرَهُم بِأَحْسَنِ مَا كَانُوا يَعْمَلُونَ ﴿٩٧﴾

Whoever is a mu'min and does good ... We will give them a different type of life.

Quran 16:97

The phrase for doing good, *‘amila salihan*, comes from the same root as salihin. Whoever does a righteous deed becomes one of the salihin, and whoever becomes one of the salihin is a believer. To such people God gives a different kind of life, *hayat tayyiba*, a clean and pure life. It is *tayyiba* because it is clean and pure of the filth of this world. These people live in this world, but they do not live in its filth. They become detached and rise above the worldly concerns that infect other people. This pure life is exactly what mystics are after.

Seeking and nothing else

This is how the mystics work, and this is the Islamic mysticism the course is about. “It is actually seeking and nothing else.” It is not about any kind of power. It is not about empowering the soul to perform wonders (*karamat*) and miracles (*mu’jiza*). The lecture calls these “shirk”. [QUERY: L01 ¶32 says of *karamat* and *mu’jizat*, “These are shirk.” Does the lecturer mean that seeking such powers as the goal of the path is shirk, or something else?] What Islamic mysticism wants is *ma’rifah* and the love of Allah. How the mystics pursue this, and what they find, is the subject of the course.

This, as the lectures put it, is who the mystics are, and why they put themselves through so much. They take on so much hardship, so much training and purification, to find a glimpse and an experience of Allah. Love for Him has been put into their hearts, and that is why they are glad to seek.